As well as the systematic discrimination that stripped the Rohingyas of their last voting rights during the run up to the 2015 elections, the complex political interaction discussed above, between the USDP, the NLD and the Buddhist extremists, has the capacity to destabilise the entire regime. As we have seen, the USDP courts the MaBaTha, and even the actions of the NLD are sometimes influenced by extremists' sectarian interpretation of what it means to be Burmese. If this does lead to even more violence in Rakhine, it is possible that the international community may be forced to take note. The USDP has continued to pass even more discriminatory legislation and Thein Sein has boasted about his role in removing the Rohingyas from civic life and in passing the new laws.[38]

The final risk is what the USDP and the military will do given their decisive electoral defeat, since every time they have contested relatively fair elections (1990, 2012, and now 2015) they have lost badly. It would appear that some factions in the USDP have been preparing for life after the election by looking for a compromise with the NLD[39] (in this respect it is worth recalling that since 2008 the USDP has been guaranteed a large block of seats regardless of votes gained).[40] An alternative, as some have suggested, is a grand alliance of Thein Sein, Shwe Mann (in effect leaders of the two factions in the USDP) and Aung San Suu Kyi. This is not so implausible, as part of such a deal could be the lifting of the legislation that currently prevents Aung San Suu Kyi from becoming president.[41]

An alternative of course is that the military decides on a coup in order to cling to power[42] and safeguard its control over the economy.[43] If so, and if it wishes to retain its current international links,[44] it will need an excuse that is more than just sour grapes at losing an election.[45] Its real motive will be to retain its economic status and this means it may only need a reason that is acceptable to those whose sole concern is their own investments in Myanmar.[46] Also, as we have seen, the military are often quite content with a degree of civil unrest, as that in turn creates a need for them to step in as 'the only real guarantors of the nation'.[47]

Therefore unrest in Rakhine may well suit their plans.[48] A renewed outbreak of violence, perhaps triggering a major refugee crisis, could easily be presented as a situation needing an urgent and unconstitutional response. In this respect it is worth noting that the 2008 Constitution is relatively unusual—it actually contains clauses that specify when it can be